

The Hindrance of Ignorance

Avijjānīvaraṇa Sutta (Iti 14)

Vuttañhetam bhagavatā vuttamarahatāti me sutam:

“Nāham, bhikkhave, aññaṃ ekanīvaraṇampi samanupassāmi yena nīvaraṇena nivutā pajā dīgharattam sandhāvanti saṃsaranti yathayidam, bhikkhave, avijjānīvaraṇam. Avijjānīvaraṇena hi, bhikkhave, nivutā pajā dīgharattam sandhāvanti saṃsaranti”ti.

This was said by the Blessed One, said by the Arahant, as I have heard:

"Monks, I do not see any other single hindrance by which people are obstructed, running and wandering in saṃsāra for such a long time, like the hindrance of ignorance. Indeed, obstructed by the hindrance of ignorance, monks, people run and wander in saṃsāra for a long time."

Etamattham bhagavā avoca. Tatthetam iti vuccati:

The Blessed One said this. In this connection, this was said:

“Natthañño ekadhammopi, yenevaṃ nivutā pajā; Saṃsaranti ahorattam, yathā mohena āvutā.

"There is no other single thing by which people are so obstructed; wandering day and night, shrouded as they are by delusion.

Ye ca moham pahantvāna, tamokhandham padālayum; Na te puna saṃsaranti, hetu tesam na vijjati”ti.

But those who, having abandoned delusion, shatter this mass of darkness, will wander no more, for the cause of their wandering is no longer found."

Ayampi attho vutto bhagavatā, iti me sutanti.

Catuttham.

This matter too was spoken by the Blessed One, as I have heard.

(Fourth)

Glossary

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
avijjā	avijjā	ignorance	Hindrance of Ignorance	The fundamental lack of understanding of the true nature of reality (impermanence, suffering, and not-self), serving as the root cause of saṃsāra.
nīvaraṇa	nīvaraṇa	hindrance; obstacle	Hindrance of Ignorance	Mental obstacles that block or veil the mind's clarity, preventing the arising of wisdom and insight.
moha	moha	delusion; confusion	Hindrance of Ignorance	One of the three primary mental defilements (<i>kilesa</i>), causing the mind to misperceive the impermanent as permanent and the unsatisfactory as satisfactory.
tamokhandha	tamokhandha	mass of darkness	Hindrance of Ignorance	Metaphor for the thick accumulation of

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
				ignorance and mental impurities that keeps the mind in spiritual blindness.
saṃsāra	saṃsāra	cycle of rebirth; wandering	Hindrance of Ignorance	The continuous cycle of birth, death, and transmigration driven by craving and delusion.

Translator Notes

1. **Ignorance as a Hindrance (*Nīvaraṇa*):** In standard terminology, five specific hindrances (sensual desire, ill-will, sloth/torpor, restlessness/worry, doubt) are discussed. Here, the Buddha targets ignorance (*avijjā*) as the ultimate global hindrance that veils humanity from truth.
2. **Delusion (*Moha*):** Used in the verse parallel to ignorance in the prose. Delusion is the active state of misperception that leads the mind to react blindly with craving or aversion.
3. **Mass of Darkness (*Tamokhandha*):** A powerful metaphor representing the deep-seated, accumulated layers of mental conditioning (*saṅkhāra*) that Vipassana meditation aims to systematically dissolve and shatter through the light of wisdom (*paññā*).